or working in a startup called Newbridge Microsystems, which employed very few people. Apprehensive about joining a startup that no one had ever heard of, Rajeev opted for the safer and more conventional choice and started working at BNR. He soon realised it was a mistake after his peers from college became successful within a few years of joining after the startup went public. “Even though I made the wrong choice in terms of financial success, BNR was a great place for research,” he says.

Even with immense potential and brilliance, Rajeev’s youthful exuberance continued at his new workplace. “I was a bit of a party animal, buying stereo systems with my money instead of focusing on work,” he recalls. For everyone else, he was just another guy working alongside the 10,000 other employees. However, a single prank on April Fool’s Day steered the course of his life in a direction that would make him the leader we know today.

It was only when his tough manager, Ed Vopni, guided him to utilise his potential that Rajeev started working towards excellence. “On April Fool’s Day, the new guy at BNR would get pranked. Out of the many pranks everyone played on me, one guy locked me out of my IBM mainframe account, raising the fear that I had been fired. For 15 minutes, I was sweating until they all shouted, ‘April Fool’s!’ and made fun of me,” narrates Rajeev.

Swearing to get back at them, Rajeev managed to knock out the UNIX accounts on the workstation for the pranksters. Within fifteen minutes, everyone realised what had happened, and he was called in by his manager, Ed Vopni, a tough guy who, in any other situation, would not have tolerated such behaviour. However, Vopni recognised Rajeev’s brilliance and told him to channel this tenacity into his actual work to succeed. “That conversation shook me out of a long deep slumber, and I realised that I needed to work harder to make something of myself,” he recalls.

Rajeev began taking every course that BNR offered, especially in VLSI. Within six months, he started working on various VLSI semiconductor chips and EDA software. “During a meeting, some potential partners offered an ASIC solution to BNR. I suggested moving away from schematic methods and using logic synthesis to launch the ASIC offerings,” he shares.

While everyone else on the team dismissed it as youthful idiosyncrasy, Vopni supported Rajeev’s idea. “That was the first time I felt validated by someone I respected,” Rajeev says. For young Rajeev, this small acknowledgement from a manager who had been tough on him gave him a glimpse into what hard work could